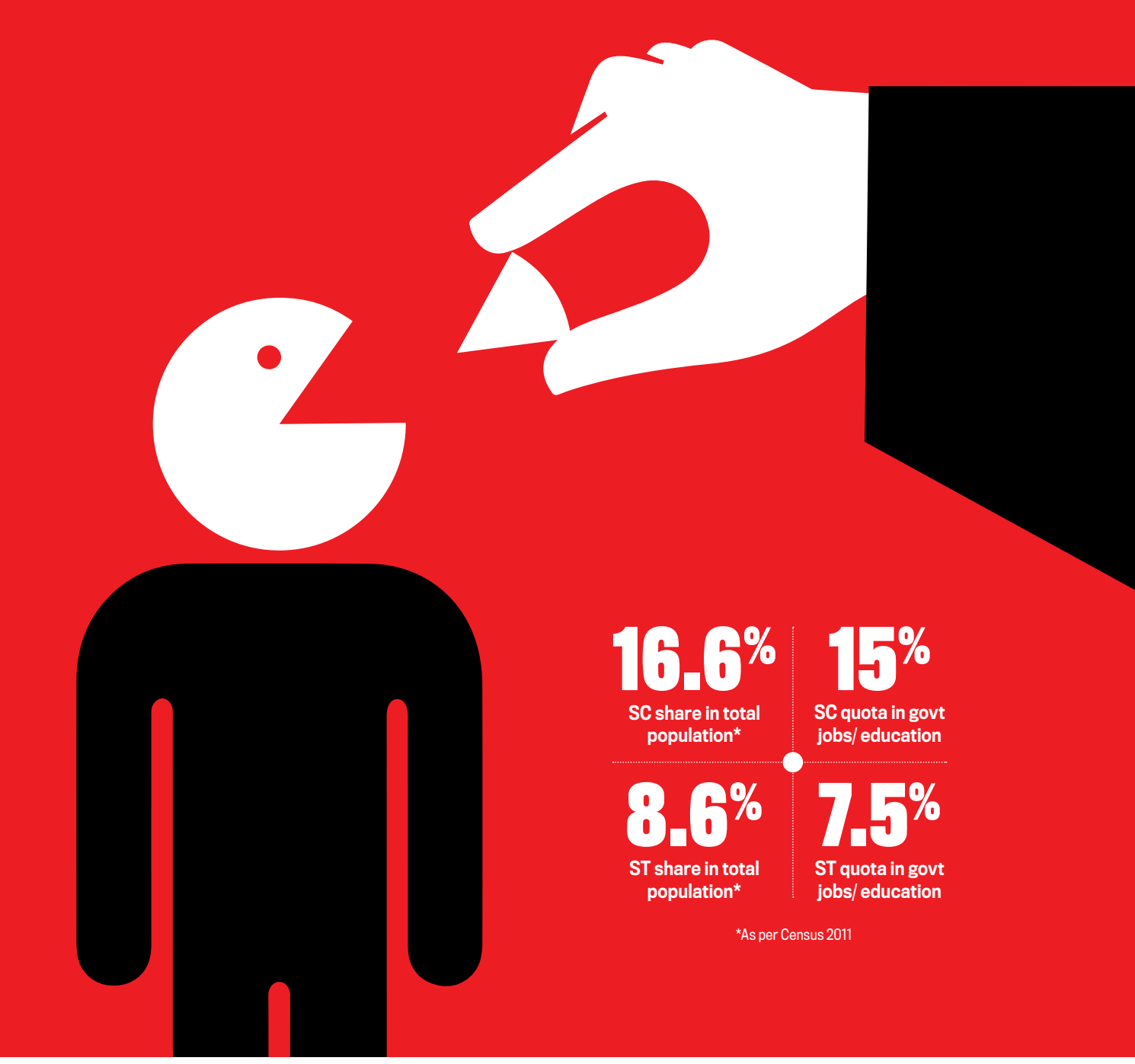


Illustration by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

RESEARCH MAY SUPPORT THE SOCIAL JUSTICE ARGUMENT THE JUDGMENT RELIES ON, BUT THE POLITICAL CLASS MAY EXPLOIT THE WELL-INTENTIONED RULING TO CULTIVATE VOTE BANKS

this list. This time, it's not just the Paswans, other larger and dominant caste groups are uneasy about the subclassification ruling.

Several other politicians representing Dalits have criticised the verdict. Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati has argued that SCs/ STs have experienced atrocities as a group. Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi chief Prakash Ambedkar has questioned why equitable representation isn't implemented among the general category if subclassification is justified for SCs, STs and OBCs. Lok Sabha MP and Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) chief Chandra Shekhar Azad has called the verdict an attempt to divide Dalits, arguing that it cannot be implemented without a caste census. The judgment, in fact, could fuel demands for a nationwide caste census, a key electoral plank for the Opposition. Especially as the court, while upholding the states' powers to create subclassifications, cautioned that the basis must not be a mere whim or political gain, but quantifiable and demonstrable data that could justify the backwardness of a caste. "This reminder